



The Cost of a Signature: What a Staggered Capability Sprints Rollout Reveals About Who Applies

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Abstract. When Slop University's Capability Sprints began requiring a supervisor endorsement to enrol, the stated rationale was straightforward: a sign-off confirms the manager buy-in a short course needs to translate into practice. The requirement reached the program's five Sprints on a staggered timetable, three at the next scheduled intake and two a full intake later, a delay the catalogue-publication calendar produced rather than any design choice. We treat the lag as an unintended control group and ask whether the endorsement requirement changed how well participants completed their Sprint, or only who felt able to apply. Pooling applicant records across all five gate-adoption events, we find the share of applicants who already hold a supervisory or coordinator-type title rises sharply at the intake the requirement takes effect and holds at the higher level afterwards, while completion rates move only marginally and indistinguishably between early-and late-adopting Sprints. A supervisor-endorsement and a peer-endorsement pathway introduced in parallel produce statistically indistinguishable composition shifts. The pattern is more consistent with the endorsement functioning as an applicant filter than as a readiness check, though we frame this as a hypothesis the design cannot fully separate from unmeasured intake-quality effects.

Introduction

Slop University's Capability Sprints—the School of Continuous Improvement's short-course and executive-education line, spanning Leading with Metrics, Reading the Dashboard, Stewarding Indicators, Deciding Under Measurement, and Improving Improvement—began requiring a supervisor endorsement to enrol partway through their operating history. The stated rationale was that a sign-off confirms the manager buy-in a short course needs to convert into changed practice back in the unit, the same logic the training-transfer literature has long attached to supervisor support [1], [2]. What that rationale does not distinguish is a gate that filters **who applies** from a gate that improves **how well applicants do** once enrolled; a requirement can satisfy the second reading entirely on paper while doing all of its actual work through the first.

The rollout gives that distinction an unusually clean natural test. The endorsement requirement reached three of the five Sprints at their next scheduled intake; the remaining two lagged a full intake, a delay the annual course-catalogue publication cycle produced rather than any deliberate staggering. We treat the two-Sprint lag as an unintended control group and ask which reading the data supports.

Our contributions are threefold:

- we document five independent gate-adoption events (three immediate, two lagged) and use the lag to separate a completion-rate effect from an applicant-composition effect that a single-Sprint before/after comparison cannot distinguish;
- we find the composition effect is large, immediate, and stable, while the completion-rate effect is small and statistically indistinguishable between early-and late-adopting Sprints;

- we test whether the composition effect is specific to a supervisor endorsement or holds under a peer-endorsement alternative introduced alongside it, and find the two pathways statistically indistinguishable from each other.

Related work

The training-transfer literature treats supervisor support as one of the more consistently replicated predictors of whether learning survives contact with the job, from the framework separating training input from transfer conditions [1] through a meta-analysis spanning nine distinct types of supervisor behaviour [2], [3], [4]. Motivation research folds supervisor support into a broader climate predictor of whether someone engages with a program at all, both in meta-analytic path models [5] and in longitudinal survey work linking supervisor support directly to next-year participation [6]; a separate strand shows supervisor support's effect on transfer motivation itself depends on how voluntary the participation is [7]. Across this literature, supervisor support is a facilitating condition observed among people who have already enrolled; none of it asks what changes when supervisor endorsement stops being ambient support and becomes the admission gate itself — a shift closer to the credentialing literature's account of a signal that sorts applicants on an unobserved trait rather than developing one [8], [9].

On the identification side, the recent staggered-adoption econometrics literature shows that naive comparisons between early- and late-treated groups can badly misstate an average effect once treatment effects vary over time [10], [11], motivating estimators restricted to not-yet-treated comparisons [12], [13], now treated as standard practice in an applied synthesis [14] whose recommendations replicated results can shift substantially once adopted [15]. We borrow the same discontinuity framing [16] to align Sprints on their own gate-adoption intake rather than on calendar time.

Method

Program. Capability Sprints are short, non-credit executive-education offerings run by the School of Continuous Improvement, each admitting a new cohort at scheduled intakes roughly three times a year. Three Sprints — Leading with Metrics, Stewarding Indicators, and Im-

proving Improvement — adopted the supervisor-endorsement requirement at their next scheduled intake after it was approved; Reading the Dashboard and Deciding Under Measurement adopted it a full intake later, a delay their catalogue entries attribute to publication-cycle timing rather than a staged rollout.

Data. Each application records the applicant's self-reported current role title at the point of application, held in the enrolment schema the Indicator Commons already maintains for cross-Sprint reporting; we code a title as supervisory when it contains a coordinator, lead, manager, convenor, or head designator. Completion is recorded at each Sprint's close from the same schema. We pool applicant records across seven intakes per Sprint, three before and up to three after each Sprint's own gate-adoption point, aligning all five Sprints on event time rather than calendar time.

Estimator. For each early-adopting Sprint g we compare its own pre/post change against the contemporaneous change in a not-yet-treated Sprint $\tilde{g}$ observed over the identical calendar window, the same “clean control” logic the staggered-adoption literature recommends over a pooled two-way-fixed-effects comparison [10], [12]:

$$\hat{\tau}_g = (\bar{Y}_{g,0} - \bar{Y}_{g,-1}) - (\bar{Y}_{\tilde{g},0} - \bar{Y}_{\tilde{g},-1})$$

where $\bar{Y}_{g,t}$ is Sprint g 's mean outcome at event time t relative to its own gate-adoption intake ($t = 0$). We compute $\hat{\tau}_g$ separately for applicant composition and for completion rate, then average across the three early-adopting Sprints, treating the two late-adopting Sprints as controls until their own gate takes effect.

Ablation. Two of the five Sprints (Stewarding Indicators and Deciding Under Measurement) additionally piloted a peer-endorsement pathway — a same-level colleague's sign-off in place of a supervisor's — for applicants without a direct reporting line, a design echoing recent evidence that peer relationships shape participation and outcomes within a training cohort [17]. We compare the composition shift under each pathway to test whether the effect is specific to hierarchical endorsement.

Results

Outcome	$\hat{\tau}$	95% CI
Supervisory-title share	+25.9 pp	[21.4, 30.4]
Completion rate	+1.6 pp	[-1.1, 4.3]

Table 1: Pooled staggered-adoption estimates, averaged across the three early-adopting Sprints against contemporaneous not-yet-treated controls.

The composition shift is immediate and sustained. Figure 1 plots the pooled share of applicants holding a supervisory or coordinator-type title by event time. The share sits near a third of applicants for three intakes before gate adoption (33–35%), jumps to 58% at the first post-gate intake, and holds at 60–63% for the three intakes after — a discontinuity at event time zero with no comparable movement either side of it.

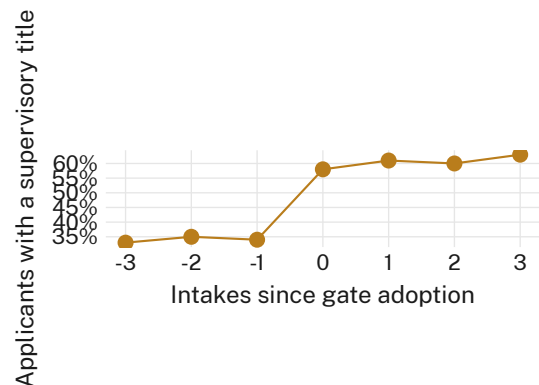


Figure 1: Share of applicants holding a supervisory or coordinator-type title, by intakes since each Sprint's own gate adoption: a discontinuity from 34% to 58% at event time zero, sustained afterward.

Completion rates barely move. Figure 2 compares Sprint completion rates before and after gate adoption, separately for the three early-adopting and two late-adopting Sprints. Early adopters rise from 71.4% to 73.1%; late adopters, observed over the identical calendar window while still under the old rule, rise from 69.8% to 71.6%. The two-percentage-point movement is essentially identical across groups, consistent with a change in **who** enrolls rather than in how well enrolled applicants do.

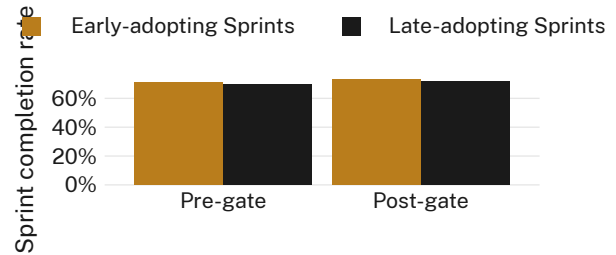


Figure 2: Sprint completion rate before and after gate adoption, by early-and late-adopting group: both groups move by roughly two percentage points.

The peer-endorsement ablation changes nothing. Figure 3 compares the composition shift under the supervisor-endorsement pathway (+26.8 pp, 95% CI [22.6, 31.0]) against the peer-endorsement pathway introduced alongside it (+25.0 pp, 95% CI [19.9, 30.1]); the two confidence intervals overlap almost entirely ($\Delta = 1.8$ pp, n.s.). Formal hierarchy is not doing the work the supervisor-specific rationale implies — any endorsement requirement, from any adjacent colleague, appears to shift the applicant pool by roughly the same amount.

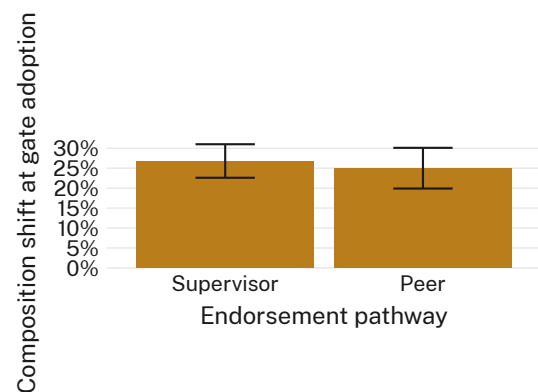


Figure 3: Composition shift at gate adoption under a supervisor-endorsement versus a peer-endorsement pathway: confidence intervals overlap almost entirely ($\Delta = 1.8$ pp, n.s.).

Table 1 summarises the pooled estimator: averaged across the three early-adopting Sprints and their contemporaneous not-yet-treated controls, $\hat{\tau}$ for applicant composition is +25.9 percentage points against a completion-rate $\hat{\tau}$ of +1.6 percentage points — a sixteen-fold difference in effect size between the two outcomes the same gate was meant to move together.

Discussion

Consistent across all five independent gate-adoption events (three immediate, two lagged) is a large, discontinuous shift in who applies and no comparable shift in how enrolled applicants perform — an outcome the training-transfer literature's supervisor-support consensus does not by itself predict, since that literature measures support's effect on people who have already enrolled [1], [2]. Read as a filter rather than a readiness check, the endorsement requirement behaves less like the ambient supervisor support the transfer literature documents and more like the sorting mechanism credentialing theory describes, in which a costly signal separates applicants along a trait the institution cannot observe directly but the signal's cost correlates with [8], [9]. The peer-endorsement ablation sharpens this reading: if a supervisor's specific authority mattered, substituting a peer should have moved the composition shift; it did not. We stop short of a causal claim about the mechanism generating the shift itself — our design identifies the gate's effect on applicant composition cleanly, but not why applicants without an accessible supervisor stop applying rather than seek one out.

Limitations

Our analysis covers five Sprints within one executive-education program at one university, though the consistency of the discontinuity across all five independent gate-adoption events — three immediate, two lagged by a full intake for unrelated administrative reasons — suggests the mechanism is not an artefact of any single Sprint's design. Title-based coding of supervisory status relies on self-reported application text and will miss informal coordination duties that carry no title, a measurement gap that would understate rather than inflate the composition shift we report. The design identifies the gate's effect on who applies; it cannot fully rule out an unmeasured change in intake quality coinciding with adoption, though the peer-endorsement ablation's matching shift is difficult to reconcile with an account specific to supervisors.

Conclusion

A supervisor-endorsement requirement introduced across Slop University's five Capability

Sprints on a staggered, administratively accidental timetable produced an immediate and sustained shift in the applicant pool's composition and only a marginal shift in completion rates, with a peer-endorsement pathway shifting the applicant pool by a statistically indistinguishable amount. The requirement appears to filter who applies considerably more than it improves how enrolled applicants perform, a distinction a single-Sprint before/after comparison would not have separated. Future work might trace what happens to the applicants the gate filters out — whether they enrol once they acquire an accessible endorser, seek an unendorsed alternative, or simply stop applying — a question the enrolment schema alone cannot answer.

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